Winter plant care knowledge

White standard edition

Seasonal growing & plant care.

Light and suitable warmth

Seedlings need bright light to make food. Winter light can be limited. Long pale growth or leaning can be a clue to check the light, rather than proof of healthy growth. Use an adult-approved bright indoor position. Keep trays away from heaters and cold draughts. Needs vary by crop.

Water after checking

Check the growing medium and drainage with the adult. Keep it lightly moist, without pooled water. Water gently only when the check shows it is needed. Let excess water drain and empty the catch tray safely. A daily check does not mean daily watering. Remove a germination cover once shoots emerge.

Room for roots

Thinning removes selected surplus seedlings to give others room. Pricking out moves a small seedling to its own space. Do this only if the crop and seedlings are ready, with adult guidance. Our pea seedlings usually stay with an intact root ball when potted on. Do not pull tangled roots apart. Waiting is a valid choice.

Winter plant care knowledge continued

White standard edition

Moving seedlings only when ready

The adult checks the crop, leaf growth, root room and access needs. A small seedling for pricking out should be robust enough to handle, with a few true leaves. True leaves have the developing shape of the plant. Readiness is not a fixed number of days.

For a suitable small seedling, loosen medium gently with a blunt tool. Support roots and hold a leaf gently, without pulling the stem. Place it in a prepared hole, settle medium and water as needed. The adult models first and stops if roots resist.

Our large-seeded peas usually move with an intact root ball into a larger pot if needed. Avoid pulling seedlings from a tangled group. No move is needed just to finish a task. The adult may demonstrate with a separate suitable plant or ask pupils to rehearse with an empty pot.

Thinning gives remaining plants more room. Ask the adult which seedlings, if any, need removal. Work only when this can avoid damaging neighbours. No sharp cutting tool is needed in this lesson.